

# Squire — Audio Commission Brief (for the music composer / sound designer)

Hand this whole document to the composer. It is an analytical inventory of the game's current audio, a critique of where it falls short, and an itemized commission list with creative direction and technical specs. The audio **engine** is finished (see [scripts/sfx.gd](#)); only the **content** is placeholder.

## The game in one paragraph

**Squire** is a darkly comic *Princess Paladin* tribute where you play the **traitor sidekick**. You fetch potions/weapons for an auto-battling Princess Paladin across waves — but you can also **sabotage** her (cursed gifts), **tip off** monsters, and **scheme**. A **suspicion meter** rises until she snaps — **"SHE KNOWS."** — and Phase 2 becomes a boss fight where she hunts *you* and monsters defect to your side. Win = the hero dies ("LONG LIVE THE SQUIRE"). Lose = you die ("EXECUTED FOR TREASON").

**Scope of this commission:** original audio for **everything** — a full **adaptive, suspicion-reactive score** plus **bespoke replacements for all 37 SFX keys** (combat, events, UI, ambient).

## Tonal North Star (read this first)

Subversive fairy-tale told from the **villain's** seat. Pixel-art Godot tribute → a **heroic chiptune x orchestral hybrid** fits (chip leads/arps over orchestral pads & percussion), but the palette is the composer's call. The through-line across the whole score:

*A bright, dutiful hero's theme that slowly curdles into menace as you betray her, snaps into operatic dread at the turn, and resolves into a hollow, morally-ambiguous coronation.*

Phase tones: **Serving** = deceptively bright/dutiful with a mischievous undercurrent (you are scheming under the fanfare). **Betrayal** = the mask drops, tragic-but-furious. **Boss** = frantic underdog-villain being hunted, driving and desperate. **Win** = dark, hollow triumph. **Lose** = tragicomic failure.

## Part A — Current audio inventory (what's used today)

Music (2 tracks, both placeholder CC0):

| Logical name   | Where it plays                   | Trigger      |
|----------------|----------------------------------|--------------|
| <b>serving</b> | Whole wave/serving phase (loops) | game start   |
| <b>boss</b>    | After betrayal, the hunt (loops) | the betrayal |

Music runs on a dedicated **Music** bus, default **-7 dB**, sitting *under* SFX as a bed. Volume is player-controllable (pause-menu slider). No reactivity, no other tracks.

**SFX — all 37 keys (every one a Kenney placeholder).** This is the replacement work-list:

| Key            | Fires on                                       | Current placeholder             |
|----------------|------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| swing          | Princess melee cleave (very frequent)          | rpg knifeSlice ×3               |
| enemy_swing    | Orc attack                                     | rpg chop/knifeSlice             |
| enemy_hurt     | Monster takes a hit                            | impact Punch_medium ×5          |
| enemy_die      | Monster dies                                   | impact Soft_heavy ×5            |
| player_hurt    | <b>Squire</b> hit (non-lethal)                 | impact Punch_heavy ×5           |
| player_die     | <b>Squire OR Princess</b> death (shared!)      | impact Glass_heavy ×5           |
| boom           | AoE blast (meteor/nova/shower/nuke)            | scifi explosionCrunch ×5        |
| zap            | Beam / charge / smite                          | scifi laserLarge ×5             |
| cast           | Spell wind-up whoosh (very frequent, –16 dB)   | rpg cloth ×4                    |
| dash           | Squire dash                                    | rpg cloth ×2                    |
| pickup         | Grab floor loot                                | rpg handleCoins ×2              |
| princess_drink | Hand a potion                                  | rpg metalPot ×3                 |
| princess_arm   | Hand a weapon                                  | rpg drawKnife ×3                |
| gift_curse     | Hand a <b>cursed</b> item (your sabotage tell) | rpg creak ×3                    |
| tipoff         | Tip off monsters (E)                           | rpg metalClick/Latch            |
| enrage         | Monsters enrage <i>en masse</i> (one swell)    | impact Soft_medium ×5           |
| defect         | Monsters defect to you <i>en masse</i>         | rpg metalLatch/belt             |
| explosion_big  | Plane crash                                    | scifi lowFrequency_explosion ×2 |
| crowd          | Peasant revolt                                 | impact footstep_concrete ×5     |
| infighting     | Monsters brawl each other                      | impact Generic_light ×5         |
| swarm          | The " <b>67</b> " tiny-minion gag              | impact Tin_medium ×5            |
| trap_spawn     | Trap telegraphs                                | impact Wood_heavy ×5            |
| trap_hit       | Trap strikes a target                          | impact Metal_light ×5           |
| angel          | Divine-retribution laser                       | scifi laserLarge ×5             |
| wave_start     | Wave begins                                    | ui switch20                     |
| wave_clear     | Wave cleared ("grows stronger!")               | ui switch21                     |
| levelup        | Princess levels up                             | ui switch15                     |
| betray_sting   | <b>THE turn</b> — deep WHOOM                   | scifi lowFrequency_explosion ×2 |
| betray_roar    | Princess's roar as she turns                   | impact Metal_heavy ×5           |
| win            | Victory end-card                               | ui switch31                     |
| lose           | Defeat end-card                                | impact Glass_heavy              |
| ui_click       | Button press                                   | ui click ×5                     |
| ui_hover       | Button hover                                   | ui rollover ×3                  |
| ui_toggle      | Checkbox/setting toggle                        | ui switch1                      |

**Engine facts the composer must respect** (from [scripts/sfx.gd](#)):

- **Variants per key:** the engine picks a random variant + jitters pitch  $\pm 6\%$  each play. Deliver

**3–5 short variants** for any repeating SFX (combat, footsteps, hits) — that's what keeps a horde from sounding like one looped sample. One-shots (win/lose/betrayal) can be single files.

- **Gain-staging is already dialed in** per key (e.g. **cast** –16 dB & 110 ms gap; **betray\_sting**

–2 dB & 500 ms gap). Deliver clips at a **consistent, healthy level**; do *not* pre-bake these trims — the engine applies them. Master bus has a **–1 dB hard limiter**; leave headroom.

- **Throttle gaps** collapse bursts to one voice — design mass-event sounds ( `enrage` , `defect` , `swarm` , `crowd` ) to read as **one collective swell**, not a single tiny tick multiplied.

## Part B — Critical analysis (the gaps & weaknesses)

1. **Music doesn't know the game is happening.** No reactivity to suspicion, no menu/intro track, no victory/defeat music, no breather. Biggest miss → the decided model is an **adaptive score**. 2. `betray_sting` / `betray_roar` are a **sci-fi explosion + a metal clang**. The game's whole climax — its title-drop "**SHE KNOWS**." — currently sounds like a door slamming. Deserves a composed **transition stinger**, not an SFX. 3. \* `levelup` , `wave_clear` , `win` are literally UI click switches. "**The Princess grows stronger!**" resolves with a **menu blip**. These ( `wave_start` , `wave_clear` , `levelup` , `win` ) should be musical stings, written in the score's key, not sound effects. 4. `player_die` is overloaded for two opposite outcomes. Same clip plays when the Squire dies (your failure) and when the Princess dies (your triumph / win condition). **Narrative opposites**. Recommend splitting into `squire_die` (tragic thud) and `princess_fall` (big, reverent — her fall is the win). 5. The Princess has no non-lethal hurt sound. No `princess_hurt` key — when she takes damage she's silent (only `player_hurt` exists, and that's the Squire). She's the co-lead; her getting hurt should register. New key needed. 6. `gift_curse` (your sabotage tell) is a wooden creak. The player's most important moral\* feedback — the sound of doing the bad thing. Should be a deliberate, sinister signature. 7. **Comedy is unscored**. The "67" swarm gag and the peasant revolt are played straight (tin/footstep impacts). The game is funny; the audio isn't in on the joke. 8. **Several live moments are fully silent** (no key at all): **pause/unpause**, **curse-toggle (Ctrl)**, **poison ticks** on the cursed Princess, **loot drop** from a killed monster, the **between-wave intermission**. Listed as additions in Part C-3.

## Part C — The commission list

### C-1. Adaptive score (music) — the centerpiece

The serving theme is delivered as 3 **synchronized STEMS**, not one file. All three must be **same BPM, same key, same length, loop-aligned** so the game can crossfade between them in real time as the suspicion meter climbs (game exposes `suspicion` 0–100; >85% trips the on-screen "SHE'S ONTO YOU" warning).

| Deliverable                         | File(s)                                          | Intensity / cue                                                               | Direction                                                                                         |
|-------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Title / briefing theme</b>       | <code>menu.ogg</code> (loop)                     | Intro & briefing screen — <i>currently silent</i>                             | Inviting heroic fairy-tale with a sly wink. Sets up the bait-and-switch.                          |
| <b>Serving — Layer A (calm bed)</b> | <code>serving_calm.ogg</code>                    | Suspicion 0~33%                                                               | Bright, dutiful, storybook-heroic. The "good squire" mask.                                        |
| <b>Serving — Layer B (tension)</b>  | <code>serving_tension.ogg</code>                 | Fades in ~33–75%                                                              | Same theme, soured — dissonance, a ticking/heartbeat pulse, minor-mode shading.                   |
| <b>Serving — Layer C (dread)</b>    | <code>serving_dread.ogg</code>                   | Fades in ~75–100% (peaks at "SHE'S ONTO YOU")                                 | Near-breaking. Low brass/choral menace over the theme, on the edge of snapping.                   |
| <b>Betrayal transition</b>          | <code>betrayal.ogg</code> (one-shot, ~3–6 s)     | The turn — replaces <code>betray_sting</code> / <code>betray_roar</code>      | The mask shatters. Deep WHOOM → the hero's theme inverted/weaponized. Bridges into the boss loop. |
| <b>Boss loop</b>                    | <code>boss.ogg</code> (loop, <i>replace</i> )    | Phase 2, she hunts you                                                        | Frantic, driving, underdog-villain desperation. Quote the hero theme, now monstrous.              |
| <b>Victory</b>                      | <code>victory.ogg</code> (loop or long one-shot) | "LONG LIVE THE SQUIRE" — <i>currently a UI click</i>                          | Hollow, dark coronation. Triumphant but <i>wrong</i> — you killed the hero.                       |
| <b>Defeat</b>                       | <code>defeat.ogg</code> (one-shot)               | "EXECUTED FOR TREASON" / "A POINTLESS DEATH" — <i>currently a glass break</i> | Tragicomic collapse. The schemer caught.                                                          |

Optional: a short **between-wave breather** variant, or let `serving_calm` carry the 6 s intermission.

**Engineering note (for whoever wires this in, after stems arrive):** add `Sfx.play_layers([ ... ])` (one looping `AudioStreamPlayer` per stem on the Music bus, all started in the same frame so they stay sample-aligned; layer A audible, B/C at -80 dB) and `Sfx.set_intensity(frac)` (crossfade by 0–1); call `Sfx.set_intensity(suspicion / 100.0)` each frame in the serving phase; at betrayal stop the layers, play `betrayal.ogg`, then loop `boss.ogg`. Existing `play_music()` / `stop_music()` stay for the single-track cues (menu/victory/defeat).

C-2. Replace all 37 SFX keys with originals

Same keys, same engine, original content. **Deliver 3–5 variants** for every repeating key; single files are fine for one-shots. The world is fantasy — steer *away* from the current sci-fi clips.

**Combat / actors:** `swing` light clean heroic blade-swish · `enemy_swing` cruder/heavier orcish swipe · `enemy_hurt` meaty orc grunt+thwack · `enemy_die` squelchy grunt + poof · `player_hurt` sharp pained thud (you're squishy) · `boom` `arcane` concussive blast (not sci-fi) · `zap` crackling holy lightning/smite (not laser) · `cast` soft arcane shimmer-whoosh (very frequent — keep it tiny). **Split** `player_die` → `squire_die` (tragic, final) + new `princess_fall` (big, reverent — the win). Add new `princess_hurt` (soft pained cue for her non-lethal hits).

**Squire actions / gifts:** `dash` quick whoosh + footfall burst · `pickup` satisfying loot chime/clink · `princess_drink` glug + heal shimmer · `princess_arm` metallic equip/power-up · `gift_curse` *signature dark sting* (the sound of sabotage, low and sinister) · `tipoff` sneaky conspiratorial snap/whistle · `enrage` collective monstrous growl-swell · `defect` an allegiance-flip cue (a turning chord).

**Events / chaos:** `explosion_big` enormous deep boom + debris · `crowd` murmuring angry-mob swell · `infighting` chaotic scuffle/clatter · `swarm` lean into the "67" **comedy** (tiny squeaks / absurd horde patter) · `trap_spawn` mechanical warning clank · `trap_hit` sharp metallic jab · `angel` **choral/holy** descending beam.

**System / UI stings** (write *in the score's key* so they sit with the music): `wave_start` brief announce/horn · `wave_clear` triumphant resolve · `levelup` ascending power-up · `betray_sting` + `betray_roar` → the composed `betrayal.ogg` · `win` / `lose` → victory/defeat tracks · `ui_click` clean tick · `ui_hover` subtle tick · `ui_toggle` toggle click.

C-3. New keys for currently-silent moments (additions)

| New key                   | Moment                                | Direction                                         |
|---------------------------|---------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| <code>pause</code>        | Open/close pause menu                 | Soft muffle/whoosh; world recedes                 |
| <code>curse_toggle</code> | Ctrl toggles curse on carried item    | Dark magical shimmer (arming the sabotage)        |
| <code>poison_tick</code>  | Cursed-potion damage tick on Princess | Faint sickly bubble (throttle long — ticks often) |
| <code>loot_drop</code>    | Item drops from a killed monster      | Light sparkle/clink                               |

Part D — Technical delivery spec

- **Format:** OGG Vorbis, **44.1 kHz, stereo**. Music loops are flagged in code, so deliver **seamlessly loopable** loops (clean head/tail).
- **Adaptive stems ( `serving_calm/tension/dread` ):** **identical length, BPM, key**, bar-aligned loop points — non-negotiable, or the crossfade drifts.
- **Levels:** consistent, healthy peaks with headroom (master has a –1 dB limiter). **Do not** pre-bake the per-key trims or the –7 dB music bed — the engine does that.
- **SFX variants:** the loader expects either an **exact-name set** or a **numbered run** `base_000 ... base_00N`. Cleanest integration: deliver originals into `assets/audio/orig/<group>/` with clean names; the `_build_library()` map in `scripts/sfx.gd` is then re-pointed **once** (single source of truth). Music goes in `assets/audio/music/` by the exact names in C-1.
- **Counts:** ~8 music items (C-1) + 37 SFX keys × 3–5 variants (C-2) + 4 new keys (C-3).

Delivery checklist for the composer

- ☐ `menu.ogg` , `boss.ogg` , `victory.ogg` , `defeat.ogg` , `betrayal.ogg` (loops/one-shots)
- ☐ `serving_calm.ogg` + `serving_tension.ogg` + `serving_dread.ogg` (same BPM/key/length, loop-aligned)
- ☐ 37 SFX keys × 3–5 variants each (fantasy palette, healthy unprocessed levels)
- ☐ Split-out: `squire_die` , `princess_fall` , `princess_hurt`
- ☐ New: `pause` , `curse_toggle` , `poison_tick` , `loot_drop`
- ☐ All OGG, 44.1 kHz stereo, seamless loops where looped